

Joy as a Distinct Regime: Evidence from Recognition-Induced Collapse

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Abstract

Joy is typically treated as a reportable affective state. Here, we test whether even minimal recognition alters it. Participants imagine a canonical “happiness” state and are then exposed to a single prompt. In the critical condition, the prompt requires only a binary recognition (“Are you in this happy state?”), and is compared to neutral and absurd prompts.

The central prediction is that recognition alone produces greater disruption than control prompts, indicating that the effect is not due to interruption, but to bringing the state into a reportable frame. Within this framework, joy is interpreted as a distinct regime (Ease) that is incompatible with even minimal monitoring. These results suggest that, for such states, measurement may function as an intervention rather than a neutral observation.

1 Introduction

Across both scientific and everyday descriptions, happiness or joy is often treated as a reportable internal state, something that can be identified, evaluated, and described without fundamentally altering its structure. Body-mapping studies, such as those by Lauri Nummenmaa, reinforce this intuition by presenting affective states as stable, spatially distributed patterns that individuals can access and communicate (Nummenmaa et al., 2014).

However, this assumption may overlook a critical property of high-intensity positive states. While such states are typically approached as measurable and introspectively accessible, there are reasons to suspect that they may be intrinsically unstable under evaluation. In particular, the act of asking whether one is currently experiencing joy may not function as a neutral query, but as an intervention that alters the state itself.

This raises a simple but consequential question: can joy survive being checked?

To address this, we propose a minimal thought experiment. Participants are invited to simulate a vivid state of happiness using a canonical bodily representation, and are then exposed to a single introspective prompt, “Are you currently in joy?”. Rather than focusing on the content of the report, the experiment targets the immediate structural effect of the question on the state itself.

If the state reliably degrades upon the introduction of such a minimal evaluative probe, this would suggest that joy is not merely difficult to measure, but structurally incompatible with the act of measurement. Under this view, joy would not be a stable point within the ordinary space of reportable experiences, but a regime that collapses when brought under evaluative scrutiny.

The present hypothesis is that joy constitutes a structurally distinct regime of experience. The full set of assumptions underlying this proposal, referred to as the Ease theory, is summarized in Table 1.

Dimension	Low intensity Happiness	Joy (Ease regime)
Developmental trajectory	Tends to increase across the lifespan	Often becomes less accessible after adolescence
Compatibility with optimization	Compatible with goal-directed behavior and optimization	Destabilized by goal-directed optimization
Cognitive coupling	Associated with meaning and narrative structure	Destabilized by meaning-making and narrative capture
Measurement compatibility	Measurable under standard conditions	Degraded under standard measurement conditions
Temporal dynamics	Gradual and stable	Abrupt, event-like, and lock-in prone
Entry conditions	Predictable and broadly stable	Stochastic and metastable
Affective intensity	Moderate, bounded	High to extreme
Structural dependence	Broadly accessible	Access-dependent and regime-gated
Sensitivity to evaluation	Sustained under evaluation	Highly vulnerable to evaluation during entry
Sensitivity to prediction error	Peripheral, weak influence on intensity	Central, strong influence on intensity

Table 1: Happiness and Joy may obey different regime laws

2 Methods

Methods

Participants. Participants are recruited from the general population. No information is provided about the hypothesis or expected outcome.

Stimuli and induction. Participants are shown a standardized body map of “happiness” (e.g., Nummenmaa et al.) and instructed to imagine being in that state, focusing on the bodily sensation. They are given a few seconds to let the imagined state form, without any instruction to analyze or maintain it.

Procedure. Each trial consists of an induction phase followed by a single prompt.

After the state is imagined, participants receive one prompt, randomly drawn from three categories:

1. **Recognition prompt (minimal condition).**

- “Are you in this happy state?”

Participants answer yes or no, based only on their immediate experience.

2. **Neutral prompts (control condition).**

- “What day of the week is it?”
- “Are you sitting or standing?”

3. **Absurd prompts (low-relevance control).**

- “Is this feeling made of triangles?”
- “Would this exist on Mars?”

Only one prompt is presented per trial. Multiple trials are conducted with randomized prompt types.

Outcome measures. Immediately after answering, participants report what happened to the imagined state:

- Unchanged
- Slightly reduced
- Strongly reduced
- Disappeared

Key comparison. The main comparison tests whether the question “Are you in this happy state?” alters the state more than neutral or absurd prompts.

Interpretation. If disruption occurs under this minimal condition, it suggests that even direct recognition of being in the state is sufficient to alter it.

3 Discussion

Discussion

The present paradigm tests a minimal hypothesis: whether a simple recognition question, requiring only a yes/no answer grounded in immediate experience, is sufficient to alter an imagined affective state. The critical feature of the design is that the target prompt does not introduce explicit evaluation, quantification, or justification. It only asks participants to recognize whether they are in the state.

If the results show that the recognition prompt (“Are you in this happy state?”) produces greater disruption than neutral or absurd prompts, this would suggest that the instability of the state is not driven by task interruption alone. Neutral questions also introduce a cognitive demand, and absurd questions may introduce semantic conflict, yet neither directly targets the state. A selective disruption under the recognition condition would therefore indicate that the effect is tied specifically to bringing the state into a reportable form.

Within the present framework, this pattern is consistent with the hypothesis that the target state belongs to the *Ease* regime, a configuration characterized by low evaluative monitoring and the absence of instrumental control over experience (Morin, 2026). In this regime, experience unfolds without being treated as an object to be assessed, stabilized, or optimized. The recognition prompt, even in its minimal form, reintroduces a monitoring operation by requiring the participant to position themselves with respect to the state. This shift, although subtle, may be sufficient to move the system out of the permissive conditions that allow the state to persist.

Importantly, the present design isolates a lower bound. The prompt does not ask participants to rate intensity, judge authenticity, or compare alternatives. It only requires recognition. If disruption occurs at this level, then the incompatibility is not tied to complex evaluation, but to the mere act of treating the state as something to be identified and reported.

This has implications for how affective states are typically studied. Many experimental paradigms assume that introspective access is neutral, or at least does not fundamentally alter the state being measured. Under the *Ease* framework, this assumption may not hold. The act of measurement, even in minimal form, can reintroduce evaluative structure and thereby alter the very state it seeks to capture.

More broadly, these results support the idea that certain high-intensity positive states are not simply points along a continuous affective dimension, but belong to a distinct regime with different structural constraints. In particular, their persistence may depend on the absence of monitoring, making them inherently fragile under conditions of introspection.

Future work could extend this paradigm by testing variations in prompt timing, linguistic framing, and response modality, as well as by comparing imagined and naturally occurring states. However, even in its minimal form, the present design highlights a key property of the Ease regime: its incompatibility with being brought into evaluative awareness.

4 Conclusion

Conclusion

The present study isolates a minimal question: whether a simple act of recognition, expressed as a yes/no response to “Are you in this happy state?”, is sufficient to alter an imagined affective state. By contrasting this prompt with neutral and absurd controls, the design removes explicit evaluation and reduces the task to its lowest possible form of experiential access.

If recognition alone reliably produces degradation, this suggests that the instability of the state is not a byproduct of complex judgment or cognitive load, but emerges at the point where the state is brought into a reportable frame. In other words, the transition from being in the state to identifying oneself as being in the state may already constitute a structural shift.

Within the Ease framework, this finding supports the idea that such states belong to a distinct regime, one that depends on the absence of evaluative monitoring. The act of recognition, however minimal, reintroduces a form of monitoring that is incompatible with the conditions under which the state can persist. This implies that the difficulty of accessing or maintaining these states is not merely practical, but structural.

More broadly, these results challenge the assumption that subjective experience can always be measured without alteration. For certain classes of affective states, measurement may function as an intervention rather than a neutral observation. The present paradigm therefore suggests a limit case for introspective methods: there exist states for which the act of asking is sufficient to change what is being asked about.

5 References

Morin, F. (2026). A regime theory of joy: The ease regime as a permissive control configuration. figshare. <https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.31955955>

Nummenmaa, L., Glerean, E., Hari, R., & Hietanen, J. K. (2014). Bodily maps of emotions. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 111(2), 646–651.

6 Appendix A



Figure 1: Caption